

LS : MODULE 1

Understanding Life Skills: Meaning and Significance of Life Skills-WHO-Identified Life Skills- Life skills for professionals

Self-awareness: Definition and Need-Tools and Techniques of Self-awareness

Stress Management: Stress, reasons and effects- stress diaries- Four A's of stress management

Coping with emotions: Identifying and managing emotions- PATH method and relaxation techniques

Skill:

- Ability acquired through practice, to carry out certain activity smoothly and successfully.
- Ex: From tying your shoelaces to running a country
- Usually related to people, ideas and things.
- Nature and amount of skill depends upon the nature and complexity of task.

Life skills :

- Taking good care of yourself
- Interacting positively with others
- Managing challenges that come across

Taking good care → positive self image

self confidence

being motivated and happy.

Interacting positively → having healthy relationship with others

Sociable

Cooperative

Compassionate

Managing challenges → ability to figure out right thing to do

Problem solving and decision making.

Definition: According to WHO

Life skills have been defined as “ *the abilities for adaptive and positive behavior that enable individuals to deal effectively with the demands and challenges of everyday life*”

Examples of life skills:

- *Communication* → speaking clearly, listening well
- *Decision making* → choosing the best option
- *Problem solving* → handling issues calmly and wisely
- *Critical thinking* → thinking deeply and logically

- *Emotional management* → controlling anger, stress, fear...
- *Time management* → using time wisely and avoiding delay
- *Teamwork* → working well with others
- *Leadership* → guiding and inspiring others
- *Empathy* → understanding others feelings
- *Adaptability* → adjusting to changes

Top 10 Life Skills Recommended by WHO



1. Problem solving

→ helps to deal constructively with problems in lives.

→ significant problems that are left unresolved causes mental stress

and give rise to accompanying physical strain

2. Decision making

→ process of identifying and choosing alternatives based on values, preferences and

beliefs

→ helps to deal with important issues and take appropriate action

3. **Creative thinking**

→ novel way of seeing and doing things (something new)

→ 4 components

- fluency (generating new ideas)
- flexibility (shifting perspective easily)
- originality (conceiving something new)
- elaboration (building on other ideas)

4. Critical thinking

- ability to analyse information and experiences in an objective manner
- clear, rational and disciplined thinking
- critical thinkers use a group of interconnected skills to analyze, unify and evaluate

what is heard, seen, or read by them.

5. Self awareness

- being aware of self - our character, strengths, weaknesses, likes & dislikes.
- it is a pre-requisite to effective communication and interpersonal relations as well

as for developing empathy for others

6. Empathy

- ability and willingness to imagine oneself in another's place and see things through their perspective
- helps to accept others who may be very different from us
- helps improve social interactions, especially in situations of ethnic and cultural diversity

7. Interpersonal relationships

- helps to relate in positive ways with the people with whom we interact
- means being able to maintain friendly relations with family, friends and colleagues, which can be an important source of social support

8. Good communication

- express ourselves clearly and effectively both verbally and non verbally
- able to express our opinions and desires, and also our needs and fear
- being able to ask for advice and help in times of need

9. Management of stress

- recognising the sources of stress in our lives, how it affects us, and act accordingly to control these levels of stress by changing our envt: or lifestyle and learning how to relax.

10. Management of emotion

→ recognising emotions of ours and others

→ being aware how emotions influence behavior, and being able to respond to

emotions appropriately

→ intense emotions like sadness or anger can have an effect on our health if we do

not respond appropriately.

Life skills for professionals :

Positive Thinking :-

→ the idea that you can change your life by thinking positively about things.

→ You can't change the world, but you can change how you perceive it and how you react to it. And that can change the way that you feel about yourself and others, which can in turn have a huge effect on your well-being.

→ If you think about positive thinking as 'being happy', it is much easier to work out what you should do to develop habits based on it.

1. Meditation

2. Writing

3. Play



WARNING! DON'T FORCE IT

- Positive thinking is good. But you should not try to use it to block out everything negative that happens in your life.
- Sometimes bad stuff happens, and you will feel down about it. It's no good pretending that you don't because forced positive thinking can be counterproductive.
- What you need to avoid is the 'developing disaster' scenario (the 'my life is a total disaster' tape that plays in your head).
- The best way to do that is NOT to tell yourself that your life is perfect. Instead, you need to recognise what has gone wrong but set it in context.
- For example:
 - "Yes, I'm having a bad day, but tomorrow will be better. I will go home now and I will be able to think of a solution to the problem in the morning when I am less tired."

Tips to enable positive thinking:

- Gain Control of Yourself
- Don't Be A Complainer
- Learn to Relax
- Boost Your Own Morale
- Congratulate Yourself
- Learn to Channel Nerves and Tension Positively
- Learn to be Assertive

Right attitude :

→ attitude is how we respond.

→ attitude is nothing but a frame of mind.

→ can be defined as a predisposition to respond positively or negatively towards any

stimuli - be it an action, a notion, a situation, a person, or an object.

Attention to detail :

→ If a job is to be done effectively, it is imperative to consider all the fine details, plan a strategy that leaves no stone unturned, and implement it fastidiously

→ this involves: checking for accuracy of facts and figures

Checking for completion of data and tasks

Checking for consistency in the *modus operandi*

Having the big picture :

- But to be a good leader, or master of the situation , one should look at the larger picture – “not seeing the forest for the trees”
- It helps one to broaden our vision
- Seeing the bigger picture as well as paying attention to finer details helps one to be a pragmatic leader
- Stories: Farmer & Zen Master; Three stonecutters

Learning skills:

What is learning skills?

- It helps one to learn, understand and retain things better.
- accepting feedback and criticism to improve ones performance.
- It also includes, prioritizing, logical arguments, information gathering, effective communication, project management, time management, decision making, analytical skills, critical thinking, attention to detail, ability to process large amounts of information, and problem solving

Research skills :

- Research means systematic investigation for knowledge on a specific topic
- Clifford Woody describes research as “the process of defining and redefining problems; formulating hypothesis, collecting , organizing, and evaluating data; reaching conclusions; and at last, carefully testing the conclusions to determine whether they fit the hypothesis.”

Perseverance :

- Steadfastness in doing something despite difficulty or delay in achieving success.
- Perseverance is an essential element when you need to achieve a high level of success.
- It is a great tool to use, and it doesn't require any college education or training.
- It comes naturally and requires a strong will.
- It requires a higher level of patience to develop perseverance in you

Setting goals and reaching them :

A goal is the intended outcome of a task

- Helps to be more productive and have job satisfaction.
- Before setting goals, get clarity with respect to two important points
 1. Why is this goal important?- big picture
 2. Is this goal about *proving* yourself or *improving* yourself

S.M.A.R.T Goals :

Specific

Measurable

Attainable

Relevant

Time-bound

Useful tips for pursuing goals:

- Choose only a few goals at any time; need to prioritize
- Make sure that these goals pass the S.M.A.R.T criteria
- Anticipate setbacks and visualize the steps that help you overcome them
- Set deadlines and review progress
- Adopt Kaizen; take ‘small steps everyday’ towards your goal

Leadership :

- Leadership is the ability to lead or guide people towards the accomplishment of a common goal.
- A leader is one who knows the way, goes the way and shows the way. Leaders lead people by their influence and
- charisma rather than authority.

Motivation :

- Motivation is what pushes us to achieve our goals, feel more fulfilled and improve our overall quality of life.
- Understanding and developing your self-motivation can help you to take control of many other aspects of your life.
- Motivation is one of the three areas of personal skills that are integral to the concept of emotional intelligence.

Self-motivation :

- Self-motivation → the force that drives you to do things.
- People can be motivated by many things, both internal and external, such as desire to do something, love of someone, or need for money.
- motivation is a result of several factors.
- The ability to motivate yourself—self-motivation—is an important skill.

Intelligence Quotient (IQ) :

- Entire cognitive or intellectual abilities of a person to store and retrieve information, analyze and solve problems, capacity for logical reasoning.
- IQ is a measure of human intelligence found through specific tests.

Emotional Quotient (EQ) :

- Ability of a person to manage his emotions.
- Self awareness, self confidence, self motivation, self control, adaptability, commitment, optimism etc comes under EQ

Social Intelligence (SQ):

- Ability of a person to connect positively with others and get along well with them
- It's about working together, cooperating, making and keeping good relationships.
- Social intelligence is an extension of emotional intelligence.

A socially intelligent person will be :-

- Able to understand behavioral cues in other people
- Empathetic
- Able to communicate well
- Willing to listen
- Service-oriented
- Able to resolve conflicts
- Able to motivate others
- Able to choose the most effective response in a given situation

SELF AWARENESS

Self awareness :

- it refers to a conscious and ongoing attention to oneself and one's inner states.
- being aware of the self
- in wider sense, awareness of the self involves:
 - Metacognition → being aware of your thoughts and metamood i.e, being aware of your feelings.
 - Objective self-assessment of your own strengths and weaknesses
 - Accepting yourself and being confident.

Need of Self awareness :

- More productive in the classroom and at home.
- Better communication with teachers and peers.
- More confidence.
- More satisfaction with performance.
- Lead to happier and healthier students.
- Increased self-awareness leads to more self-care in medical students.
- A better understanding of one's strengths and capabilities along with a boost to emotional intelligence in law students.

How to improve Self awareness :

- ❖ asking reflective questions
- ❖ Keeping a journal
- ❖ Switching perspectives
- ❖ Practising mindfulness and meditation
- ❖ Getting honest feedback
- ❖ Taking personality and psychometric tests.

Tools and techniques of self awareness :

- Questionnaires
- Journaling
- Reflective questions
- Meditation
- Mindfulness
- Psychometric tests
- Feedback

Questionnaires :

- a questionnaire comprises a list of questions concerning a specific subject to which answers must be provided.
- A questionnaire is used by researchers in order to gather required information
- The purpose of this questionnaire is to determine your competency and skills in different fields.
- This knowledge will help you to identify those competencies and skills which may possibly cause you.

Example Question: I worry about my schoolwork

Answer: Yes or No

If you have marked A, it means that you worry about your schoolwork.

If you have marked B, it means that you do not worry about your schoolwork.

- REMEMBER that you must answer whatever is true as far as you are concerned and not answer to please other people problems. By giving the required attention to them, you may improve them.

Journaling :

- As everyone continues to ask: in the digital age, what is the use of the written word? Well, one of them is self-awareness.
- In the way society is structured today, there is just very little to no avenue to express self-awareness.
- Keeping a journal helps you keep track of your thoughts.
- The simple act of writing down how you feel aligns your mind, body, and spirit.
- It is true that one must never underestimate the power of the pen.

Reflective questions :

- it may sound too simple, but thoughtful questions are useful self-awareness tools.
- You must practice the habit of asking yourself questions that prompt introspection.
- note down at least three reflective questions at the beginning of each day, so you have the entire day to think about them.
- Raising self-awareness is a process of delving inside yourself to understand your place in the world.
- Without conscious contemplation, this is quite impossible

Meditation :

- When it comes to connecting with your inner self, nothing is more powerful than meditation.
- Quiet and peace are crucial in realizing your spiritual well-being.
- Of course, it begins with conditioning your physicality to get in touch with your inner essence. The mind and spirit soon follow.
- In the entirely still yet conscious state of meditation, your self-awareness becomes stronger than ever

Mindfulness :

- So many of us spend our days just running from moment to moment.
- We are busy, have demands coming from several different areas of life, and simply don't feel like there is time to stop and smell the roses.
- However, with a focused effort, we can take the time to slow back down.
- Through mindful living practices, we can find more happiness, joy, and meaning in our lives.
- That said, being mindful is not as easy as it sounds.
- It is a habit that you have to develop.

A list of eight habits that have helped in the quest to be more mindful.

- #1 Sit in the morning
- #2 Eat mindfully
- #3 Spend time outside
- #4 Meditate
- #5 Focus on one task at a time
- #6 Feel Feelings
- #7 Create Something
- #8 Engage in Physical Activities You are Passionate About

Psychometric tests :

- Measuring attributes like height, weight, and strength is reasonably simple.
- But what about factors that aren't so easy to measure?
- Traits such as personality, intelligence, attitude, and beliefs are important characteristics to measure and assess.
- One way to gather this information is through psychometric tests.

- Psychometric tests can measure interests, personality, and aptitude.
 - ***Interest tests*** measure how people differ in their motivation, values, and opinions in relation to their interests.
 - ***Personality tests*** measure how people differ in their style or manner of doing things, and in the way they interact with their environment and other people.
 - ***Aptitude tests*** measure how people differ in their ability to perform or carry out different tasks.

Feedback :

- The definition of effective feedback as that which is clearly heard, understood and accepted.
- Those are the areas that are within your power. You have no control over whether the recipient chooses to act upon your feedback, so let's put that to one side.
- Develop your feedback skills by using these few rules
 1. Feedback should be about behavior not personality
 2. Feedback should describe the effect of the person's behavior on you
 3. Feedback should be as specific as possible
 4. Feedback should be timely
 5. Pick your moment

- Always thank the person who has given you the feedback.
- They have already seen that you have listened and understood, now accept it.
- Acceptance in this way does not mean that you need to act on it.
- Do them the courtesy of at least giving the matter some consideration.

STRESS MANAGEMENT

Stress :

- Stress is the body's reaction to any change that requires an adjustment or response. The body reacts to these changes with physical, mental, and emotional responses.
- Stress is a normal part of life.
- You can experience stress from your environment, your body, and your thoughts.

Stress management:

- Early man-dangers; extreme weather, wild animals, hostile clansmen etc.
- Choice is “fight” or “flight”
- A cocktail of hormones released into bloodstream like adrenaline and cortisol; Preparing the body to respond to the threat and take immediate action by increasing the blood pressure, heart rate, breathing speed, muscle tension, and sharpness of senses
- Today the world is much safer a place to live in
- The “fight” or “flight” response is so deeply ingrained in us
- Thus Stress is the body’s way of responding to any demand or threat it faces
- When body starts responding in such a manner repeatedly, stress becomes harmful and causes damage to your health, career, relationships, personality, and quality of life.

Reasons and effects of stress :

- Academic or workplace pressures
- Hectic schedules
- Major life changes
- Financial problems
- Family problems
- Pessimism
- Uncertainty
- Negative self-talk
- Perfectionism

Identifying stress

- Stress manifests itself in different forms
 - ***Cognitive effects:*** problems with memory and concentration, anxious thoughts, and continuous worrying
 - ***Emotional effects:*** feeling unhappy or depressed, anxiety, irritable behaviour, loneliness, isolation, feeling overwhelmed
 - ***Physical effects:*** unexplained pain, digestive problems, nausea, chest pain, increased heart beat rate, and frequent illness
 - ***Behavioural effects:*** Disrupted appetite and sleep, reduced social interaction, procrastination, substance abuse, and repetitive behaviour like nail biting

Stress management techniques:

- It is impossible to completely avoid stressors in our lives
- It is possible to regulate our responses to them; stress then stays in tolerable limits
- Use a STRESS DIARY.

STRESS DIARY :

- First step → recording and analyzing stressors and our response to them
- Difficult to identify the triggers that cause stress responses.
- Keeping a record of ‘anxious moments’ helps pinpoint stressful situations, key stressors and the manner in which we react to these stresses
- Stress diary is used to record information about stressful experiences on a regular basis either at regular intervals or when a stressor causes you to react accordingly

Stress diary format :

- Date and Time
- The most recent stressful experience you had
- How happy you feel on a scale of 0 (unhappiest) to 10 (happiest)
- Your current mood
- How effectively you are working now: from 0 (most ineffective) to 10 (most effective)
- Fundamental cause of stress
- The physical symptoms that you felt (butterflies in the stomach, anger, headache, raised pulse rate, sweaty palms, and so on)
- How well you handled the problem; did you solve the problem or made things worse?

- Analyse stress diary after few days
- The different stresses experienced, assessment of fundamental causes, and your responses will give an idea about the major issues that affect you in this regard.
- Most frequent and most unpleasant stressors can be identified from a thorough examination of the diary
- The focus of this analysis should be to identify the most potent stressors and modify your responses to them.

Four A's of stress management :

One of the most comprehensive approaches to dealing with stress can be summarized using four A's of stress management

1. *Avoid*
2. *Alter*
3. *Accept*
4. *Adapt*

Avoid :-

- Avoid situations and people who cause you to be stressed.
- Can be done by modifying your circumstances, avoiding people who cause you to become tensed, learning to say no politely, prioritizing and planning.
- Prior planning and prioritization will help schedule tasks in such a manner that you can avoid becoming stressed about not being able to do important things.
- Ex. No to a movie invitation for an assignment
- Ex. Leaving early to avoid traffic

Alter :-

- Involves modifying situations in whatever manner possible to reduce stress.
- Communicating clearly, politely, and openly with others, time management, planning, having a realistic estimate of the situation will help immensely in changing a potentially stressful situation for the better.

Accept :-

- When a stressful situation cannot be avoided or altered, one often has no choice but to accept it.
- Important to accept such situations with an open mind
- Can be done by practicing forgiveness, acknowledging one's own feelings and emotions about the situation, and trying to maintain a positive outlook.

Adapt :-

- An important skill required to navigate life without becoming overly stressed is to learn to adapt to circumstances.
- Most situations become stressful because of our high expectations
- Ask questions like; Will this matter five years from now?, How important is this in the larger scheme of things?

Stress management techniques

- ***Breathing Exercise***- regulate breathing and shifting our focus to that rhythm
- ***Meditation***- A practice or technique by which an individual focuses their attention on a particular entity to attain a calm and clear mental state
- ***Cognitive reframing***- adopting a different way of looking at things ex. A tough examination can be seen either as a catastrophe or as a learning experience
- ***Regular exercise and appropriate diet***- physical activity and adequate nutrition help in eliminating stress to a large extent.

- ***Mindfulness***- the practice of being completely aware of and immersed in the present moment without dwelling on the past or having anxious thoughts about the future
- ***Better Social Relationships***- Friends and family can provide us emotional support, encouragement, and taking on our responsibilities when we need time off.

Stress management approaches:

Strategies to reduce stress falls under three categories based on their orientation:

1. Action oriented approach
2. Emotion oriented approach
3. Acceptance oriented approach

Action oriented approach

Stress is on taking appropriate action to change the stressful situation.

- Time management and planning
- Delegating /learning to say No
- Managing conflict with other people
- Modifying work/home environment

Emotion oriented approach

A significant portion of the stress that we experience stems from internal factors, mostly from the manner in which we perceive a situation.

By changing our viewpoints and paradigms we can reduce such stress

- Cognitive reframing
- Positive thinking
- Being aware of thoughts and thought patterns, thereby avoiding unsuitable thoughts.
- Using affirmations and visualizations

Acceptance oriented approach

When a given situation cannot be altered and is genuinely bad, it becomes essential to accept it gracefully.

Acceptance is not always easy.

Minimizing stress when changing the situation is beyond us

- Meditation
- Physical exercise
- Interpersonal connections and social support
- Coping with change

Resilience

- We cannot go through life without experiencing any setback.
- Resilience is the ease with which one recovers from the setbacks that life throws at them.
- Thomas Alva Edison failing over a thousand times before he could make an incandescent lamp
- Resilient people do not linger on the bad feelings that failure brings; they view failure as an opportunity, reevaluate and move on.
- Resilience has three essential components:

- Resilience has three essential components:
 - ***Challenge*** → learn to see the adverse situation as an opportunity rather than as a catastrophe.
 - ***Commitment*** → being resilient means being committed.
 - may be to a cause, ideal, activity, person, oneself
 - provides the motivation to overcome current bad situation and move on.
- ***Personal control*** → these people have control over where they focus their thoughts, they try to dwell on their strengths and take action within their power to mitigate the situation.

Gratitude journaling : popular and seemingly effective method to reduce stress

- Writing down the things for which we are thankful
- When we are faced with adversity, we tend to forget that life has given us good things too
- A gratitude journal may be written daily or at regular intervals
- Make a conscious decision to be happier and less stressed

COPING WITH EMOTIONS

Emotions:

Strong feelings that are beyond reasoning or knowledge, stemming from one's circumstances, mood, or interpersonal relationships.

Emotions result in psychological changes that affect our behavior.



Emotion wheel

Identifying emotions

- What am I feeling now?
- What are my senses tell me?
- What is it that I want?
- What judgments or conclusions have I made (and are they accurate)?
- What is this emotion telling me?
- How do others feel, and how do I know?

Managing emotions

- Emotions are potent forces that can work for or against you.
- Understand your emotions correctly
- If you feel sad → take active steps to make yourself happy
- Identify other emotions like anger or disappointment, also help in guarding and others against any possible harm.
- Ex. A friend carelessly tosses away your project idea, made insulting comment – you are hurt – heart beat rate increases, muscles stiffen, feel like yelling at him, causing trouble and probably losing friendship – solution is to respectfully disagree with him, find a safe outlet for your hurt feelings.

Harmful way of dealing with emotions

Dealing with negative emotions like fear, sadness and anger are unavoidable and it is necessary to deal with them.

Some of the harmful ways that people deal with negative emotions :

- Denial → refuses to accept that anything is wrong
- Withdrawal → when a person wants to spend time alone and does not want to participate in activities with other people
 - may result in extreme loneliness, misunderstanding, anger, and distorted thinking

- Bullying → using force, threats, or ridicule to exert power over others is known as bullying.
 - Bullies feel inferior and try to gain self esteem by making others feel bad
- Self Harm → abnormal eating habits, engaging in undue risks
 - self-harm is often used as a temporary means of relieving emotional pain.
- Substance abuse → alcohol and other drugs to become numb about painful situations.
 - can lead to addiction and more serious complications like suicidal thoughts.

Path method of emotion management

Pause → take a break from the situation so that you may take appropriate action

Acknowledge → acknowledge what you are feeling

→ do not deny your feelings.

→ understand that they are legitimate

Think → think what you can do to improve the situation

Help → based on the thoughts in the previous step take action to help yourself.

Relaxation techniques

- Breath focus → take long, slow, deep breaths
→ gently remove your mind from distracting thoughts and feelings.
- Body scan → breathe deeply for few minutes
→ focus on one part of the body/ group of muscles at a time
→ mentally release any physical tension you feel
- Guided imagery → imagine soothing scenes, places, or experiences in your mind
→ helps you relax and focus

- Mindfulness meditation → sit comfortably
 - focus on your breathing
 - bring attention to the present moment
- Repetitive prayer
- Silently while practicing breath focus